



Sid Meier's *Railroads!* is a revival of the old *Railroad Tycoon* series that we've all known and loved for so long. The objective remains the same—build your own railroad empire, connect a nation, buy out your competition, and become the king of the railways. You can make your money by connecting cities so they can exchange goods and passengers, buying businesses in those cities, and dabbling a bit in the stock market.

We've reached a point where any game with the Sid Meier name comes with high expectations attached, and *Railroads!* is no doubt one of the most enjoyable games this reviewer has come across in ages. Most importantly, the game's structure has been vastly overhauled. There is just enough micromanagement—both in your finances and in

the actual building of the railroads—to make you feel like you're totally in control, but this never feels tedious.

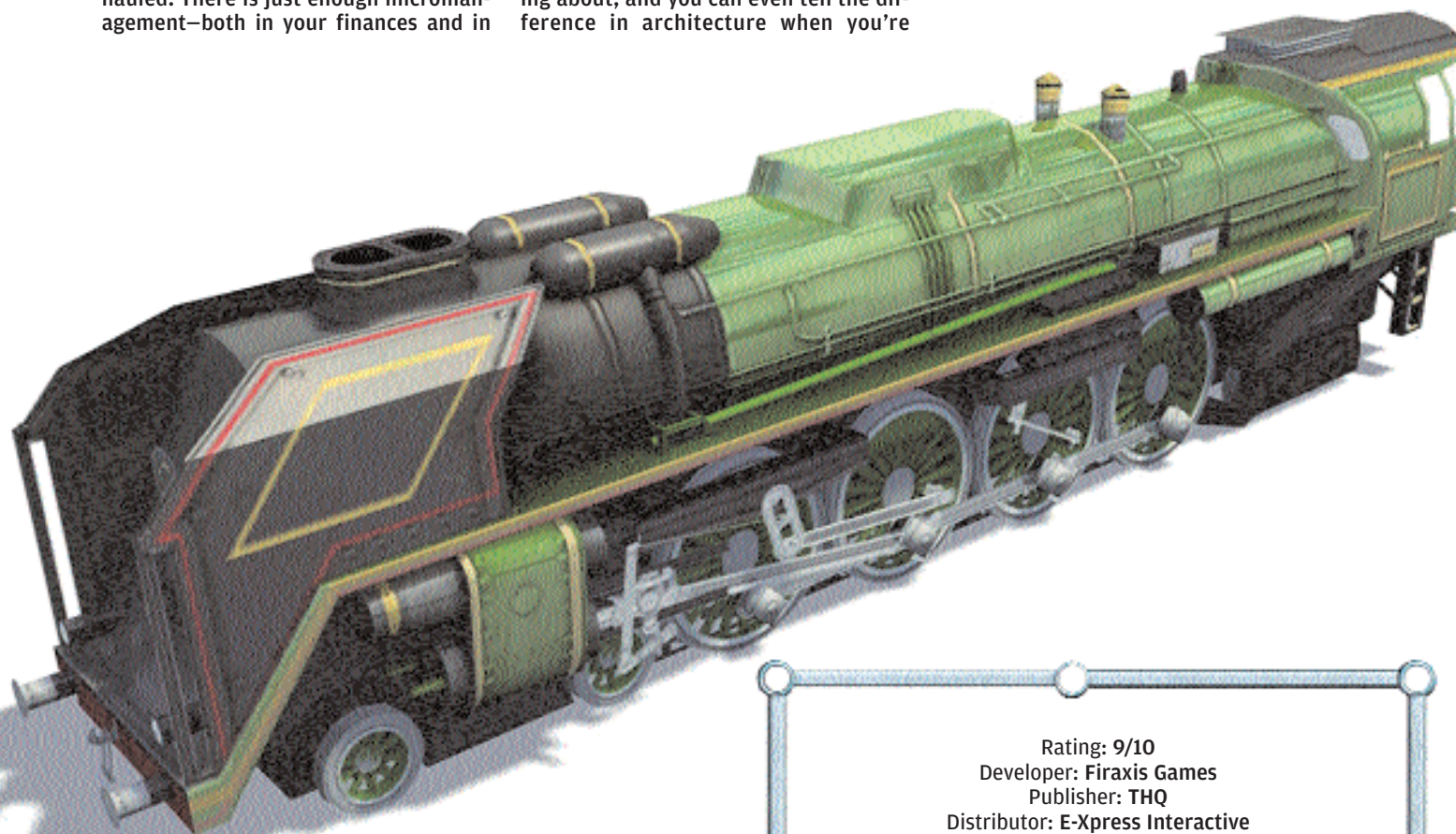
For a strategy/simulation game, I found this surprisingly fast-paced. Your opponents—the AI equivalents of greats like J.P. Morgan and the Baron Rothschild—work fast, and you're going to have to make some really quick decisions—some of which might bite you later—as you compete against them. At no point did I feel deprived of entertainment through my hours of play. Online or LAN play is even more entertaining, and the game comes with some very interesting and challenging maps to compete on.

Visually, graphics are meticulously detailed—train models are like the real things, stations have little people walking about, and you can even tell the difference in architecture when you're

building your railroad in Eastern Europe or America. All these treats come at a price, though—it's not as gentle on your graphics card as you'd expect. There are also a few aberrations here and there—trains wantonly going through houses and the like—but they're all forgiven when you look at the big picture.

That big picture is that *Railroads!* has tremendous appeal for people of all ages, shapes and sizes, and that appeal isn't going to go away soon. It's one of those few games that force you to use your brains, so grab yourselves a copy before your grey cells rot.

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Rating: 9/10

Developer: Firaxis Games

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Minimum System Requirements: Pentium 4 1.4 GHz or AMD Athlon equivalent, 512 MB RAM, DirectX 9.0c 64 MB video card